politics. But despite initial impetus with the Bodo Peace Accord and sundry projects, its reformist lure hasn't gone beyond a slim urban base. Its failure exposes the limits of saffron penetration in tribal lands—also, a touch of hubris in imagining a state-backed force could trump organic legitimacy in a region where identity runs deeper than growth narratives.

It's a sobering scenario ahead of the 2026 assembly poll for Sarma. Post delimitation, the Bodoland Territorial Region (BTR) has 15 assembly seats, representing over 10 per cent of Assam's 126-member house.



Takeaways

- **The BPF, under Hagrami Mohilary (above), sweeps 28 out of 40 seats in the Bodoland Council election**
- **The BJP, which went solo, gets only five seats, down from nine in '20. Ex-ally UPPL reduced to seven**
- **Sarma's first big electoral setback, its effects could spread to other tribal areas, impacting '26 poll**

In 2021, the BJP-UPPL combine had secured seven—later upped to eight—of BTR's then-11 seats. Though a slender numerical bundle, it lent a special lustre to the NDA's 75-seat majority in the state.

A MATH PROBLEM

It's not only the idea of cross-ethnic embrace that's threatened. If voting patterns hold, the BJP risks losing six to eight Bodo seats, potentially the difference between comfortable governance and coalition haggling. Sarma's prompt pivot to embrace Mohilary—declaring within hours that "BPF is part of NDA" and "all 40 BTC seats are with NDA"—betrays the depth of his worry. The BJP faces an unenviable choice: grovel before the very leader it spurned in 2020, potentially alienating the UPPL or, worse, risk facing a united Bodo opposition.

Mohilary holds all the cards in the transactional negotiation that may ensue. His campaign framed the poll as a defence of Bodo autonomy against outside interference, with slogans like "Bodoland isn't for sale", a barely veiled swipe at the BJP's centralising tendencies. Yet, having governed the BTC for 17 years, the former insurgent commander is pragmatic enough to know tribal councils need state and central largesse. BPF has long sided with the ruling party in Dispur, but in 2020 the BJP dumped it for UPPL. Now, he has the leverage to extract the maximum from Dispur and Delhi. Also, to control next year's seat-sharing.

The Congress, on its part, reaffirms its irrelevance in Bodoland. In 2020, it had one seat—it dropped even that. Non-Bodos form 65 per cent of BTR's population, including big Muslim blocs that used to back the Congress. This time, tellingly, they gravitated toward the BPF—given its more inclusive tone versus the BJP's polarising rhetoric.

Overall, the mood may infect Assam's other autonomous councils, especially Karbi Anglong and Dima Hasao, widening the potential assembly poll impact zone. If other local forces peddling identity politics revisit their alignments, parties like the Congress will look to get a foot in the door. Sarma's tactical skills are thus presented with an unforeseen challenge. ■

▶ RAJASTHAN

THE 'PILOT EPISODE' FLIES AGAIN

Charges fly back and forth as Gehlot camp counters clean chit to 2020 rebellion

By **Rohit Parihar**

IT SHOULD HAVE BEEN A MINOR EPILOGUE, an act of formal closure. But a court order has drawn the curtains back on one of the most controversial chapters in Rajasthan politics in recent times: Sachin Pilot's revolt of 2020, which had almost split the then Ashok Gehlot government.

Tough conversations have resumed around the 'Pilot episode'. Innuendo and recrimination fill the air again; allegations and rebuttals are flying back and forth between various camps of the Congress, as well as between the ex-CM and top BJP leaders, the surround sound made more lurid by leaked audio clips and phone-tapping charges.

'CASUAL CHATTER'

Months ago, the state Anti-Corruption Bureau (ACB) had filed a closure report before the trial court, saying it had found no evidence of bribery, horse-trading or conspiracy to topple the Gehlot regime. The intercepted phone calls said to clinch the claim contained only "casual political chatter", it held. The file had been lying with the ACB court, with only skirmishes elsewhere disturbing the peace. But the Rajasthan High Court, on September 16, took note of the closure report and disposed of the petition by the two accused seeking quashing of FIR as infructuous. Now, the trial court will decide whether to accept or reject the closure report.

Yet, for many, the ACB's closure